Comprehensive Analysis of Gearboxes in Battery Electric Vehicle (BEV) Auxiliary Motor Systems

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Executive Summary

This report provides a comprehensive analysis of the gearboxes utilized in the auxiliary motor systems of Battery Electric Vehicles (BEVs). As the automotive industry accelerates its transition to electrification, the design and efficiency of all vehicle components, including auxiliary systems, have come under intense scrutiny. These systems, which include power seats, windows, mirrors, and HVAC controls, are critical for vehicle functionality and passenger comfort [54]. Their performance is heavily reliant on the integration of small electric motors, many of which employ gearboxes to modulate speed and torque [39].

Our analysis reveals that while the primary drivetrains of BEVs are predominantly moving towards single-speed transmissions, the auxiliary motor landscape is more diverse [45]. The choice between a direct-drive motor and a geared motor is application-specific, hinging on a delicate balance of torque requirements, speed, efficiency, size, noise, and cost [39, 42]. For most auxiliary functions that require high torque at low operational speeds—such as moving a seat, lifting a window, or adjusting a mirror—geared motors are the prevalent and most practical solution [39].

The report examines the three primary types of gearboxes employed in these applications: planetary, worm, and spur. Planetary gearboxes are favored for their high torque density, efficiency, and compact, concentric design, making them ideal for applications like power seat adjustment [1, 4]. Worm gearboxes, characterized by their high reduction ratios and inherent self-locking capability, are frequently used in window regulators, providing a safety feature that prevents the window from being forced down [2, 10]. Spur gearboxes, being the simplest and most cost-effective, are found in less demanding, lower-torque applications [3, 5].

A critical aspect of gearbox design is the gear ratio, which dictates the trade-off between output speed and torque [11]. This analysis details the typical gear ratios found in various auxiliary systems. Power seat motors often use ratios from 20:1 to over 100:1 to generate sufficient force [14]. Window regulators can have exceptionally high ratios, sometimes reaching up to 2000:1, to provide the necessary lifting torque from a small motor [15]. Mirror adjustment motors also use high ratios to ensure precise, controlled movement [19].

Material selection is another key determinant of gearbox performance, durability, and cost. While traditional high-load gearboxes rely on hardened and alloy steels, auxiliary systems increasingly utilize advanced engineering plastics like Polyoxymethylene (POM) and Polyamide 66 (PA66) [26, 27]. These materials offer benefits such as reduced weight, quieter operation, and corrosion resistance [28, 29]. They are often enhanced with reinforcements like glass or aramid fibers and internal lubricants like PTFE to improve their mechanical properties and wear resistance [28, 29].

Finally, the report addresses the industry-wide push for weight reduction. The mass of every component, including auxiliary gearboxes, is scrutinized to maximize vehicle range and efficiency [32]. Techniques such as topology optimization, the use of hollow gears, and the strategic selection of lightweight materials like aluminum and engineering plastics are being employed to reduce the weight of these components without compromising their structural integrity or performance [32, 33]. The integration of an appropriate gearbox allows for the use of smaller, lighter motors, contributing further to overall vehicle weight savings and efficiency [38].

In conclusion, the gearbox is a critical enabling technology for a wide range of auxiliary functions in modern BEVs. Its design, material composition, and integration with the motor are pivotal in achieving the required performance, efficiency, and reliability. As BEV technology continues to evolve, the optimization of these small but essential components will remain a key focus for automotive engineers and suppliers.

Introduction to Auxiliary Motor Systems in BEVs

The global automotive industry is undergoing a profound transformation, driven by the shift from internal combustion engines (ICE) to battery electric vehicles (BEVs). This transition is not limited to the primary propulsion system but extends to every subsystem within the vehicle. Auxiliary systems, which encompass all non-propulsion functions, are a critical area of development [54]. These systems, responsible for passenger comfort, convenience, and safety, include power windows, seat adjusters, mirror controls, heating, ventilation, and air conditioning (HVAC) systems, and active grille shutters [54]. In a BEV, these functions are powered by a low-voltage electrical system, typically 12V, which is sustained by an auxiliary battery [55]. This battery is, in turn, charged by the main high-voltage traction battery via a DC/DC converter [57].

The efficiency of these auxiliary systems has a direct and measurable impact on the overall energy consumption and, consequently, the driving range of the BEV [56]. Unlike in ICE vehicles, where waste heat from the engine can be repurposed for cabin heating, BEVs must generate all thermal energy and mechanical power from the battery [58]. This places a premium on the efficiency of every component, including the small electric motors that drive auxiliary functions.

A key component in optimizing the performance of these motors is the gearbox. Most auxiliary applications require low-speed, high-torque motion—a characteristic that is often the opposite of a small DC motor's native output, which is typically high-speed and low-torque [39]. A gearbox acts as a mechanical torque converter, reducing the motor's rotational speed while proportionally increasing its output torque [11]. This allows for the use of smaller, lighter, and more energy-efficient motors to perform tasks that would otherwise require much larger, heavier, and more power-intensive direct-drive units [38, 42].

This report provides a detailed examination of the gearboxes used in BEV auxiliary motor systems. It explores the prevalence of geared systems versus direct-drive alternatives, analyzes the different types of gear mechanisms employed, and investigates the specific gear ratios, materials, and design considerations for various applications. Furthermore, it discusses the impact of gearbox selection on motor specifications and the ongoing efforts in weight reduction to enhance overall vehicle efficiency. By synthesizing technical data and industry trends, this report aims to offer a comprehensive understanding of the role and significance of gearboxes in the evolving architecture of modern electric vehicles.

Prevalence and Market Context

The adoption of electric vehicles is reshaping the automotive transmission and gearbox market [45, 47]. While the conversation around EV transmissions often centers on the single-speed gear reducers used in primary drivetrains, a complex ecosystem of smaller, specialized gearboxes underpins the functionality of numerous auxiliary systems. The prevalence of these gearboxes is intrinsically linked to the design philosophy of each specific application, balancing performance requirements against constraints of cost, space, and weight.

Currently, the vast majority of BEVs utilize single-speed transmissions for their main propulsion [44]. This approach simplifies the drivetrain, reduces mass and energy losses, and leverages the electric motor's ability to deliver high torque across a broad range of speeds [45]. However, a trend toward multi-speed transmissions is emerging in the high-performance segment, with manufacturers like Porsche and ZF developing two-speed and even three-speed systems to enhance efficiency, particularly at highway speeds [44]. This broader market trend highlights the industry's focus on optimizing every aspect of the powertrain for maximum range and performance, a principle that extends to auxiliary systems.

For auxiliary functions, there is no single dominant approach; the choice between a geared motor and a direct-drive motor is highly dependent on the specific task. Direct-drive motors, which connect the motor shaft directly to the load, offer advantages in simplicity, reliability, and efficiency due to the absence of gear-related friction and backlash [39, 43]. They are often quieter and provide smoother, more precise motion, making them suitable for applications like high-fidelity haptic feedback or precision robotics [39]. However, to generate significant torque at low speeds, a direct-drive motor must be considerably larger, heavier, and more expensive than a comparable geared motor [41, 42].

Consequently, for the majority of automotive auxiliary applications, geared motors are the preferred solution [39]. Functions such as adjusting a power seat, lifting a car window, or actuating an HVAC blend door require substantial torque to overcome inertia and friction, but do not require high speed. A geared motor provides the necessary torque multiplication, allowing a small, cost-effective DC motor to perform these tasks efficiently [39]. The use of a gearbox enables designers to select a motor that operates in its most efficient speed range, converting its high-speed, low-torque output into the low-speed, high-torque motion required by the application [38]. This approach not only saves space and weight but also reduces overall energy consumption.

While precise market share data for geared versus direct-drive auxiliary motors is not readily available, the functional requirements of these systems strongly indicate a high prevalence of geared solutions. The European automotive market, a leader in the transition to electrification, provides a clear context for this trend. With BEV market share reaching over 20% in early 2026 in key markets like the UK and Germany, the demand for all associated components, including auxiliary motor gearboxes, is growing rapidly [49]. The broader industrial gearbox market in Europe, valued at approximately $10.2 billion in 2026, is significantly influenced by the automotive sector's shift towards EV production, which demands high-performance, precision-engineered components for both assembly lines and the vehicles themselves [46]. The principles of efficiency, compactness, and cost-effectiveness that drive the selection of geared motors for auxiliary functions are aligned with the overarching goals of BEV development, ensuring their continued and widespread use.

Types of Auxiliary Motor Gearboxes

The selection of a gearbox for an automotive auxiliary application is a critical design choice that influences performance, durability, noise, and packaging. The three most common types of gearboxes used in these systems are planetary, worm, and spur gearboxes [1]. Each has a distinct set of characteristics that makes it suitable for specific functions within the vehicle.

Planetary Gearboxes

Planetary gearboxes, also known as epicyclic gear trains, are renowned for their high torque density and compact size [4]. Their unique construction consists of a central “sun” gear, an outer ring gear (or annulus) with internal teeth, and several “planet” gears that rotate between the sun and ring gears, held in place by a carrier [9]. Power is typically transmitted from the motor to the sun gear, which then drives the planet gears. As the planet gears orbit the sun gear, they also mesh with the stationary ring gear, causing the planet carrier to rotate. The output shaft is connected to this carrier [4].

The primary advantage of this design is its ability to distribute the load across multiple gear teeth simultaneously [2]. This load sharing allows planetary gearboxes to handle significantly higher torque than a spur gearbox of a similar size [4]. This high torque capacity, combined with their concentric input and output shafts, makes them exceptionally compact and ideal for applications where space is at a premium, such as power seat adjustment mechanisms [5]. Furthermore, the balanced distribution of forces results in high efficiency, typically in the range of 90% to 98% per stage, minimizing energy loss [4, 7]. They are also known for their smooth and relatively quiet operation [2]. However, the complexity and precision required in their manufacturing process make them more expensive than simpler gearbox designs [2, 4]. Automotive applications for planetary gearboxes are numerous, including power seat drives, electric parking brake (EPB) systems, and large headlight regulators, where high torque and reliable, smooth operation are essential [4].

Worm Gearboxes

Worm gearboxes are composed of a worm, which is a screw-like gear, and a worm wheel, which resembles a spur gear [10]. The worm is typically the input, driven by the motor, and its thread meshes with the teeth of the worm wheel [1]. This arrangement most commonly results in a 90-degree angle between the input and output shafts, which can be a significant advantage for packaging in tight spaces [2, 7].

The most notable characteristic of a worm drive is its capacity for very high gear reduction ratios in a single stage, often ranging from 20:1 to over 300:1 [6, 10]. This makes them extremely effective at converting high-speed motor rotation into very low-speed, high-torque output. Another key feature is their self-locking or non-reversible nature [1, 2]. Due to the high friction and the angle of the gear teeth, in most high-ratio configurations, the worm wheel cannot drive the worm [10]. This acts as a natural brake, preventing the output shaft from being back-driven. This property is highly desirable in applications like power window regulators, as it prevents the window from being manually forced down, adding a layer of security without the need for an additional braking mechanism [15]. While they operate very quietly, the primary drawback of worm gearboxes is their relatively low efficiency, which typically ranges from 30% to 60% [1, 3]. The sliding contact between the worm and the wheel generates significant friction and heat, leading to energy losses [2]. This sliding action also results in higher wear compared to the rolling action of other gear types, which must be managed with proper material selection and lubrication [1, 2].

Spur Gearboxes

Spur gearboxes are the simplest and most common type of gear system [1]. They consist of one or more pairs of straight-toothed gears mounted on parallel shafts [3]. By meshing a small gear (pinion) with a larger gear, speed is reduced and torque is increased. Multiple stages can be stacked to achieve higher reduction ratios [1].

The main advantages of spur gearboxes are their simplicity and low manufacturing cost [1, 2, 3]. They are straightforward to design and produce, making them a cost-effective solution for many applications. They also boast high efficiency per stage, often up to 91%, as the rolling contact between the teeth results in minimal friction [5]. However, spur gears have several disadvantages. The engagement of the straight-cut teeth is abrupt, which can generate considerable noise, especially at higher speeds [1, 2, 3]. This characteristic makes them less suitable for applications where quiet operation is a priority. Additionally, because only one or two pairs of teeth are in contact at any given moment, their load-bearing capacity is lower than that of planetary or helical gears of a similar size [1, 2]. This concentrated stress can lead to increased wear over time, particularly under heavy or shock loads. In the context of automotive auxiliary systems, spur gears are typically found in lower-torque, lower-precision applications where cost is a primary driver and noise is not a major concern.

Gear Ratios in Auxiliary Applications

The gear ratio is the most fundamental parameter of a gearbox, defining the relationship between the input speed from the motor and the output speed of the gearbox [11]. It is a direct multiplier of torque and a divider of speed [12]. A high gear ratio, such as 100:1, means the motor must turn 100 times to produce one rotation of the output shaft, resulting in a 100-fold increase in torque (minus efficiency losses) and a 100-fold decrease in speed [13]. The selection of an appropriate gear ratio is therefore critical to tailoring the motor's performance to the specific demands of each auxiliary function, ensuring sufficient force, controlled movement, and optimal energy efficiency [11].

Power Seat Adjustment Motors

The primary requirement for a power seat motor is to generate enough torque to move the entire seat assembly, often while it is occupied, which represents a significant load. Speed is a secondary concern; the movement should be smooth and controlled, not jarringly fast [14]. Consequently, seat adjustment motors employ gearboxes with medium to high gear ratios. Typical ratios for these applications range from 20:1 to 50:1, with some designs for heavier seats or more precise adjustment mechanisms extending to 100:1 or even higher [14]. These high ratios allow a compact, relatively low-power DC motor to produce the substantial force needed for fore/aft, height, and recline adjustments [18]. The use of a high-ratio planetary gearbox is common, as it provides the necessary torque multiplication within a small physical package that can be easily integrated into the complex structure of a modern car seat [18]. The high ratio also provides finer control resolution, allowing for small, precise adjustments to the seat's position [14].

Power Window Regulator Motors

Power window regulators face a similar challenge: lifting a heavy pane of glass against the friction of its seals [16]. This requires significant torque, especially during the initial movement or when dealing with icy conditions. Speed, while desirable for user convenience, is less critical than the ability to reliably move the window. For this reason, window regulator motors are equipped with gearboxes that have very high reduction ratios [15]. The range for these ratios is exceptionally wide, from as low as 5:1 to as high as 2000:1 in some designs [15]. A common configuration involves a worm gear drive, which not only provides a large reduction in a single stage but also offers the crucial benefit of being self-locking [15, 16]. This inherent braking action prevents the window from being pushed down from the outside and holds it securely in any position without continuous power to the motor [16]. The motor's high-speed rotation is thus converted into the slow, powerful, and secure linear motion needed to raise and lower the window [17].

Power Mirror Adjustment Motors

The adjustment of side-view mirrors requires a different balance of properties. The load is very light, so high torque is not the primary driver. Instead, the emphasis is on precision and fine control, allowing the driver to make minute adjustments to the mirror's angle [19]. While the torque requirement is low, a direct-drive motor would be too fast and difficult to control accurately. Therefore, mirror adjustment motors use gearboxes with high gear ratios to slow down the movement to a manageable and precise speed [19]. The output speed for these motors is typically in the range of 10 to 30 RPM [19]. To achieve this from a standard small DC motor, gear ratios can be quite high, with examples like 1:120 being common [19]. These ratios, often achieved through compact spur or planetary gear trains, translate the rapid rotation of the motor into the slow, deliberate movement needed for accurate mirror positioning [18]. The high ratio enhances control resolution, meaning a small input from the driver's control corresponds to a very small, precise movement of the mirror [20].

HVAC Actuator Motors

Automotive HVAC systems rely on a series of small actuators to control blend doors, which mix hot and cold air, and mode doors, which direct airflow to the vents (e.g., defrost, panel, floor) [22]. These actuators must provide enough force to move the doors against airflow pressure and hold them in specific positions to regulate temperature and distribution accurately. The movement needs to be precise and repeatable over tens of thousands of cycles [22]. While specific gear ratios are not standardized, the principles of linear actuators suggest that moderate to high ratios are used. Ratios in the range of 20:1 to 150:1 are common in similar small-scale actuation tasks [21]. This level of gear reduction allows a small stepper or DC motor to generate the necessary torque to overcome resistance and provides the fine positional control required for precise climate regulation [23]. Worm gears are sometimes used for their self-locking properties, ensuring that a blend door remains in its set position without constant power, while planetary or spur gear trains are also employed depending on the specific packaging and performance requirements of the actuator [25].

Material Composition of Auxiliary Gearboxes

The choice of materials for gearbox components is a critical engineering decision that directly impacts performance, durability, weight, noise, and cost [26]. In automotive auxiliary systems, a careful balance is struck between the high strength of traditional metals and the versatile properties of modern engineering plastics. The selection depends heavily on the specific application's load, speed, and environmental conditions.

Steel and Metal Alloys

For components subjected to high stress, high loads, or requiring maximum durability, steel remains the material of choice [26]. In the context of automotive gearboxes, including some heavy-duty auxiliary applications, gears are typically manufactured from case-hardened steels, such as 20MnCr5, or other alloy steels like 4140 and 4340 [26]. These materials undergo heat treatment processes to create a very hard, wear-resistant surface (the "case") while maintaining a tougher, more ductile core [26]. This combination provides excellent resistance to the surface wear and fatigue that occurs at the gear tooth contact points, while the tough core prevents catastrophic fracture under shock loads. Alloying elements like chromium, molybdenum, and nickel are added to enhance properties such as hardenability, strength at elevated temperatures, and corrosion resistance [26]. Gearbox shafts, which must transmit torque and withstand bending forces, are also commonly made from high-strength alloy or carbon steels [26]. The gearbox housing, which must provide rigid support for the internal components, is often made from cast iron for its strength and excellent vibration-damping properties, or from aluminum alloys when weight reduction is a primary design driver [26].

Engineering Plastics: POM and PA66

In many modern auxiliary motor gearboxes, where loads are lower and other factors like weight and noise are more critical, engineering plastics have become increasingly prevalent [27]. These advanced polymers offer a compelling set of advantages, including significant weight reduction, inherently quieter operation due to their damping properties, and excellent corrosion resistance [28, 29]. They can also be manufactured into complex shapes with high precision via injection molding, which can be more cost-effective than machining metal parts [27]. Two of the most common plastics used for gears are Polyoxymethylene (POM) and Polyamide 66 (PA66) [29].

Polyoxymethylene (POM), also known as acetal or Delrin, is a highly crystalline thermoplastic valued for its high stiffness, strength, and excellent dimensional stability [29]. It has a very low coefficient of friction and good self-lubricating properties, making it an ideal material for gears that require smooth, low-wear operation [29]. A key advantage of POM is its low moisture absorption, which means its mechanical properties and dimensions remain stable even in humid environments [28]. This makes it particularly suitable for precision gears where tight tolerances must be maintained. However, its application is limited by a relatively low melting temperature (around 160°C), and it may require lubrication under continuous high loads [27, 28].

Polyamide 66 (PA66), a type of nylon, is another high-performance engineering thermoplastic widely used in automotive components [30]. It is known for its exceptional strength, toughness, and heat resistance, with a melting point between 255–265°C, allowing it to be used in higher-temperature environments than POM [30]. PA66 also exhibits good wear resistance and a low friction coefficient, especially when paired with appropriate lubricants or additives [30]. Its primary drawback is a tendency to absorb moisture from the environment, which can cause dimensional changes and affect its mechanical and electrical properties [30]. Designers must account for this behavior when using PA66 for precision components.

Reinforcements and Additives

To overcome the inherent limitations of base polymers and tailor them for more demanding applications, plastics are often compounded with various reinforcements and additives [29]. These enhancements can significantly improve the mechanical and tribological properties of the resulting material.

Glass Fibers (GF) are a common reinforcement used to increase the strength, stiffness, and heat deflection temperature of both POM and PA66 [29]. Adding glass fibers can substantially boost the load-bearing capacity of a plastic gear. For example, a POM gear reinforced with 28% glass fibers can exhibit a 50% increase in load capacity compared to its unreinforced counterpart [28]. However, the orientation of these fibers can affect wear characteristics; improperly oriented fibers can sometimes lead to abrasive wear on mating metal surfaces [28].

Aramid Fibers (such as Kevlar) provide ultra-high strength and stiffness at a very low weight [29]. When added to a plastic matrix, they can improve fatigue life and inhibit the propagation of cracks, leading to more durable and reliable gears [29].

Internal Lubricants like Polytetrafluoroethylene (PTFE) and graphite are frequently blended into the plastic resin [29]. These additives migrate to the surface of the gear teeth during operation, reducing the coefficient of friction and improving wear resistance. This allows for “lubricated for life” or even dry-running gear systems, reducing maintenance requirements and eliminating the risk of lubricant contamination [29]. The combination of a base polymer like PA66 with glass fiber reinforcement and a PTFE lubricant creates a composite material with a balance of strength, stability, and low friction, making it highly suitable for many automotive auxiliary gear applications [31].

Weight Analysis and Optimization

In the pursuit of maximizing the range and overall efficiency of Battery Electric Vehicles, weight reduction, or “lightweighting,” has become a paramount design objective. Every gram saved contributes to reducing the energy required for acceleration and overcoming rolling resistance, thereby extending the vehicle’s operational range on a single charge. This focus on mass reduction extends to all components, including the often-overlooked auxiliary motor gearboxes [32]. The weight analysis of these components involves a multi-faceted approach, combining advanced design techniques, strategic material selection, and manufacturing process optimization.

A primary method for reducing the weight of gearbox components, particularly the gears themselves, is through targeted material removal. This is not simply a matter of making parts smaller, but rather intelligently redesigning them to remove non-load-bearing material while maintaining structural integrity. Finite Element Analysis (FEA) is a powerful computational tool used extensively in this process [32]. Engineers can create detailed digital models of a gear and simulate the stresses it will experience under operational loads. This analysis reveals areas of low stress where material can be safely removed without compromising the part’s strength or lifespan [32]. A common technique is to drill circular holes through the web of a gear. Studies have shown that this can result in a material saving of around 2% per gear [32]. While this may seem minor, the cumulative effect across millions of vehicles is substantial. A 2% reduction in gear mass can lead to a 7% increase in the torque and power transmitted per unit of weight, enhancing the component’s efficiency [32]. On a macro scale, this level of material saving in automotive transmissions can translate to significant reductions in fuel or energy consumption over the vehicle’s lifetime [32].

Topology optimization is a more advanced form of this design philosophy. It is an algorithmic approach where a computer model determines the most efficient distribution of material within a defined space for a given set of loads and boundary conditions [33]. This process often results in complex, organic-looking structures that are highly optimized for strength-to-weight ratio. When applied to a gearbox housing, for example, topology optimization has been shown to reduce weight by over 8% while simultaneously decreasing deformation and stress under load [33]. This not only makes the component lighter but also stiffer and more robust.

Material selection is another critical lever for weight reduction. The shift from traditional materials like steel and cast iron to lightweight alternatives is a key strategy. Aluminum alloys are often used for gearbox housings, offering good strength and durability at a fraction of the weight of cast iron [26]. Even more significant weight savings are achieved through the use of engineering plastics like POM and PA66 for gears and other internal components in low-to-moderate load applications [27]. These plastics are inherently less dense than metals, and their ability to be molded into complex net shapes can further reduce part count and overall assembly weight.

The design of the gearbox itself also plays a crucial role. Planetary gear systems, for instance, are favored in many modern applications not only for their performance but also for their high power-to-weight and torque-to-weight ratios [34]. Their ability to distribute loads across multiple planet gears allows them to transmit high levels of torque within a very compact and lightweight package compared to a traditional spur gear system with an equivalent reduction ratio [34]. This inherent efficiency in design contributes directly to the overall goal of vehicle lightweighting. By combining these strategies—intelligent design through FEA and topology optimization, strategic material substitution, and the selection of inherently efficient gearbox architectures—engineers can significantly reduce the weight of auxiliary motor gearboxes, contributing to the enhanced performance and range of the next generation of electric vehicles.

Impact on Motor Specifications and System Integration

The integration of a gearbox has a profound and direct impact on the selection and specification of the electric motor it is paired with. The gearbox acts as a crucial intermediary, fundamentally altering the performance characteristics of the motor to match the requirements of the auxiliary application [38]. This relationship allows for a systems-level approach to design, where the motor and gearbox are optimized as a single unit to achieve desired outcomes in terms of performance, size, weight, and cost.

The most significant impact of a gearbox is its function as a torque multiplier and speed reducer [11]. A small, high-speed DC motor is generally efficient, lightweight, and cost-effective, but it produces very little torque [39]. By pairing this motor with a high-ratio gearbox, its low torque can be amplified to a level sufficient to move a heavy load, such as a car seat or window. This means that instead of using a large, heavy, and expensive direct-drive motor designed for high torque at low speeds, engineers can select a much smaller and more economical motor [38, 42]. This has cascading benefits for the entire vehicle design, contributing to weight reduction, lower power consumption, and reduced packaging space requirements. The choice of gear ratio is therefore a primary determinant of the motor's required specifications. A higher gear ratio allows for a smaller motor, while a lower ratio would necessitate a motor with greater inherent torque [14].

The gearbox also plays a vital role in optimizing the motor's operational efficiency. Electric motors do not operate at peak efficiency across their entire speed range. Typically, they have an optimal operating point or range where they convert electrical energy into mechanical power most effectively [38]. A gearbox allows the motor to run at or near this high-efficiency speed, even when the final output application requires a much slower movement. By gearing down the speed, the system ensures that the motor is not forced to operate in an inefficient, low-RPM, high-current state, which can lead to overheating and reduced lifespan [38]. This improves the overall energy efficiency of the auxiliary system, minimizing its drain on the vehicle's battery and contributing to a longer driving range.

Furthermore, the gearbox helps in matching the inertia of the motor to the inertia of the load. A significant mismatch in inertia can lead to poor dynamic response, control instability, and potential damage to the system. A gearbox with a reduction ratio (GR) reduces the load inertia as seen by the motor by a factor of the square of the gear ratio ($1/GR^2$) [38]. This makes it much easier for the motor to accelerate and decelerate the load, resulting in a more responsive and stable system. This is particularly important in applications requiring precise positional control, such as mirror adjustment or HVAC blend door actuation.

The choice of gearbox type also influences the system. A planetary gearbox, with its high efficiency, ensures that a maximum amount of the motor's power is delivered to the output [4]. A worm gearbox, while less efficient, provides self-locking, which can eliminate the need for an external brake or for the motor to be constantly energized to hold a position, thereby saving energy [10]. The inherent noise and vibration characteristics of the gearbox type (e.g., noisy spur gears vs. quiet worm gears) also affect the selection, as they contribute to the vehicle's overall noise, vibration, and harshness (NVH) profile, a key factor in perceived quality and passenger comfort [1, 3]. In essence, the gearbox is not merely an add-on but an integral part of the electromechanical system, enabling the optimization of the motor and the overall auxiliary function for the specific demands of the modern electric vehicle.

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